EMPLOYEE PHISHING AWARENESS GUIDE

How to Identify, Avoid, and Report Phishing Emails

1. What Is Phishing?

Phishing is a cyberattack in which criminals impersonate trusted organizations or individuals to trick people into revealing sensitive information, clicking malicious links, downloading harmful attachments, or making unauthorized payments. Phishing messages may appear to come from banks, delivery companies, IT departments, or familiar online services.

2. How to Recognize a Phishing Email

Employees should watch for the following warning signs:

- Suspicious sender address: The sender's email address does not match the organization's official domain.
- Urgent or threatening language: The message pressures you to act immediately to avoid account suspension, financial loss, or another consequence.
- Suspicious links: Links lead to unfamiliar websites, shortened URLs, or addresses that imitate legitimate domains.
- Unexpected attachments: The email contains files you were not expecting, particularly executable files or documents requesting additional permissions.
- Requests for sensitive information: The message asks for passwords, verification codes, payment details, or confidential company information.
- Unusual content: Generic greetings, unexpected offers, spelling mistakes, or inconsistent branding may indicate phishing.

Important: A professional-looking email or a message that passes email authentication checks is not automatically safe.

3. What to Do When You Receive a Suspicious Email

- **Stop:** Do not respond immediately, even if the message appears urgent.
- **Check:** Examine the sender's full email address and the message for warning signs.
- **Avoid clicking**: Do not open suspicious links, download attachments, or provide personal information.
- **Verify independently:** Contact the organization using its official website, app, or a previously known phone number.
- **Report:** Use your organization's phishing-reporting procedure or inform the IT/security team. Do not forward the email to colleagues.

4. What to Do If You Already Clicked

- Stop interacting with the suspicious website or attachment.
- Immediately inform the IT/security team and explain what happened.
- If you entered a password, change it through the legitimate website using a trusted device and notify IT.
- If financial information was shared, contact your bank or payment provider.
- Follow IT instructions for checking your device and securing affected accounts.

5. Everyday Phishing Prevention Tips

- Use strong, unique passwords and enable multi-factor authentication (MFA).
- Keep your operating system, browser, and security software updated.
- Access important accounts through official websites or bookmarked addresses.
- Be cautious with unexpected payment requests, account alerts, and delivery notifications.
- Report suspicious messages promptly, even when you are unsure whether they are malicious.

REMEMBER: STOP → CHECK → VERIFY → REPORT

When in doubt, verify the message independently before taking action.